

12 Confusing Adjectives

In this lesson, we're looking at 12 adjectives that often confuse learners of English. You'll learn the differences between words like **uninterested** versus **disinterested** and **complimentary** versus **complementary**. With clear explanations, practical examples and pronunciation tips, you'll soon be able to use these adjectives accurately and with confidence. I've also included 12 additional adjectives at the end, along with a link to 2 interactive quizzes!

Uninterested vs Disinterested

uninterested /ʌn'ɪnrəstɪd/	disinterested /dɪs'ɪnrəstɪd/
not wanting to know about or be involved in sth.	able to be fair and not favour one side or the other in a situation because you're not personally involved
opposite of interested	similar to neutral or impartial
"My students seemed completely uninterested in the lesson about the history of taxation."	"We need a disinterested party to help decide who should win the prize."



Some native speakers use '**disinterested**' to mean '**uninterested**', particularly in speech or in informal situations. A lot of people consider this incorrect, but it's pretty common.

Famous vs Infamous

famous /'feɪməs/	infamous /'ɪnfəməs/
known about by a lot of people, usually for sth. positive (used for people, things and places)	well known for sth. bad (used for people, things and places)

- “Taylor Swift is a **famous** singer.”
- “She became **famous** after winning an Olympic gold medal.”
- “The Taj Mahal is **famous** for its beauty.”

- “Jordan Belfort is **infamous** for running a stock market fraud operation.”
- “Al Capone was an **infamous** gangster.”
- “That house is **infamous** for having a grisly history.”

Complimentary vs Complementary

complimentary /ˌkɒmplɪˈmentri/	complementary /ˌkɒmplɪˈmentri/
expressing praise or approval	2 people or things that work well together because they're useful together or visually appealing; can be quite different but they enhance each other
• “He was very complimentary about your presentation.”	complementary colours = blue and orange
free	• “They have complementary skills — she's creative and he's highly organised.”
• “The hotel offers a complimentary breakfast for guests.”	

Economic vs Economical

economic /ˌiːkəˈnɒmɪk/, /ˌekəˈnɒmɪk/	economical /ˌiːkəˈnɒmɪkl/, /ˌekəˈnɒmɪkl/
related to the economy, money, business or trade (followed by a noun)	not wasteful; describes sth./sb. that doesn't waste time, money or energy

“London is an important economic centre in Europe.”	“This car is more economical than that one — it uses less fuel.”
producing enough profit to continue (often used in the negative)	
“Running the bus route through that village is no longer economic.”	

Distinct vs Distinctive

distinct /dɪ'stɪŋkt/	distinctive /dɪ'stɪŋktɪv/
clearly different or separate	having a special quality that makes sth. easy to recognise or remember because it's different from other things
“The Adidas and Nike logos are clearly distinct from each other.”	“John has a very distinctive laugh.” “That building has a distinctive architectural style.”
easy to notice	
“There was a distinct smell of smoke in the air.”	



The UK has many **distinct** accents.

- Each accent is clearly different from any other.



She has a **distinctive** accent.

- The features of her accent make it easy to recognise where she's from.

Distinct is also used to emphasise that something exists or is important. It collocates strongly with ‘advantage’, ‘possibility’ and ‘lack of’.

- “Speaking multiple languages gives you a **distinct** advantage in the job market.”

Classic vs Classical

<u>classic</u> /'klæsɪk/	<u>classical</u> /'klæsɪkl/
high-quality, lasting and often seen as one of the best examples of its kind (used for books, films, clothes, cars, etc.)	music from the mid-18th to early 19th centuries, e.g. by Mozart or Beethoven
“She’s really into classic cars and has several from the 1940s.” “That black dress is classic – it’ll never go out of style.” “He left his phone at home again. Classic Julian!” ← This is typical of him. (more playful)	“I love listening to classical music when it’s played live.”
	sth. that has a long tradition
	“Classical ballet demands incredible precision and strength from every dancer on stage.”
	things related to Ancient Greek or Roman culture
	“The museum in Athens has many classical sculptures.” “He’s a classical scholar.” ← He studies Ancient Rome.



Quiz Questions & Answers

1. The wine is _____ to the rich flavour of the cheese.
complimentary complementary

2. We watched a _____ film from the 1950s last night – it’s still brilliant.
classic classical

3. We need a/an _____ judge who can make a fair decision.
uninterested disinterested

1. complimentary, 2. classic, 3. disinterested

12 Bonus Adjectives

<u>eligible</u> /'elɪdʒəbl/	<u>illegible</u> /ɪ'ledʒəbl/
qualified or entitled to be chosen or to participate in something	impossible to read or understand due to poor handwriting or print
"She is eligible for the scholarship because she meets all the requirements."	"The doctor's handwriting was completely illegible on the prescription."
<u>ingenious</u> /ɪn'dʒiːniəs/	<u>ingenuous</u> /ɪn'dʒenjuəs/
clever, original and inventive; showing great skill or creativity	honest and trusting; not trying to trick anyone
"Candice's ingenious solution to the problem saved the company thousands of dollars."	"His ingenuous smile showed he had no idea he was being deceived."
<u>discreet</u> /dɪ'skri:t/	<u>discrete</u> /dɪ'skri:t/
careful to keep things private; not drawing attention	separate things that don't connect to each other
"Please be discreet about the surprise party planning."	"The data was organised into discrete categories for analysis."
<u>last</u> /lɑːst/	<u>latest</u> /'leɪtɪst/
the final one	the newest one
"This is the last episode of the series."	"Have you seen the latest episode that came out yesterday?"

eager /'i:gə/	anxious /'æŋkʃəs/
excited and happy about something	worried or nervous about something
"The children were eager to open their presents on Christmas morning."	"She felt anxious about the job interview results."

unsatisfied /ʌn'sætɪsfɑɪd/	dissatisfied /dɪs'sætɪsfɑɪd/
still wanting or needing more of something	unhappy with something you received or experienced
"After the small meal, he was unsatisfied and wanted more food."	"The customer was dissatisfied with the poor service at the restaurant."

If you'd like to practise what you've just learnt, click the link below to access your 2 interactive quizzes!

BONUS

👉 [Click here to access the quizzes!](#)